

4. Compatibility

The contributory nature of OSS requires that standards and specifications be open so that additions and/or modifications can be easily made. Business sense dictates that product differentiation is a good strategy leading to incompatible products from different PS vendors. A user planning to switch between different PS vendors needs to consider the cost of converting existing data from the older format to the newer one. This forces users to ignore better software, and acts as an artificial barrier to competition.

5. Impact of Negative Business Practices

OSS products can be supported by any person with required expertise; this can be from any service provider. PS can be supported only by a single entity. This allows the vendor to indulge in practices that could harm the user in the long term—like offering a PS for free to drive out competition, and later increasing prices.

6. Response time

Only the PS vendor can modify the code in response to an attack or to add a feature; users have to wait till such an event. OSS is enriched by newer features contributed by many programmers. The decentralised nature of the OSS development allows for faster incremental changes to OSS. Users with specific needs can customise the software either personally or with the aid of any knowledgeable person.

1.2.4 The forces behind the Open Source movement

Three entities are central to this movement : Richard Stallman, Linus Torvalds, and the Open Source Initiative. Richard Stallman is the original ideologue of the movement who started off to create an entire free OS—GNU. He also founded the Free Software Foundation. Linus Torvalds is the programmer who created the kernel—a central part of an operating system—that completed Stallman's GNU. And the Open Source Initiative, formed by Eric Raymond and Bruce Perens after having disagreed with Stallman's strict interpretation of free software, is responsible for having taken the movement to the masses, albeit by diluting the original ideology. How these three entities changed the software landscape is a gripping tale.